LIGHT ON A BLIGHT

- **The SC Muchi community was denied entry to a temple in Gidhagram village in West Bengal for centuries**
- **This March, with the help of the administration and talks with privileged castes, they were finally allowed in**
- **The incident highlighted other such temples in Bengal—which has a large Dalit population—where some SC communities are systematically excluded**
- **Large Dalit groups like Namashudras and Rajbangshis have political influence and escape discrimination**
- **Small groups like Muchis face the brunt of caste bias**

allegations of a similar practice of discrimination against Muchis were received by the Rabidas Ruidas Rishi Das Charmakar Chamar Muchi Aikya Mancha, an umbrella organisation of the cobbler community. However, after interventions from the court and local administration, the community has been allowed to enter the temples in both these places.

The state's Dalit population stands at 21.4 million (2011 Census), with 60 sub-groups. The two largest communities—Rajbangshis (18 per cent of the population) and Namashudras (16 per cent)—have also faced discrimination, but are less vulnerable as they're concentrated in some districts, giving them political influence. In contrast, the Muchi/ Chamar community, comprising 4.8 per cent of Bengal's Dalits, remains marginalised.

"Discrimination against communities such as cobblers is rampant because they are fewer in numbers," says Dalit researcher and author Kumar Rana. "They are treated with discrimination because otherwise, the so-called 'upper castes' will not get cheap labour," he says.

Dalit activist and author Narayan Biswas describes casteism in Bengal as being "sugar-coated". "Like the rest of India, the disease of casteism exists in Bengal. However, since it is home to the second-largest Dalit population in India, 'upper castes' find it difficult to discriminate openly. Instead, they maintain social superiority through practices like denying entry into certain temples under the guise of tradition," he explains. Biswas points out that casteist tendencies were evident during Left rule too. "When land reforms were implemented, the elite castes did not resist as they were not directly engaged in farming. But they ensured Dalits were kept away from intellectual spaces," he adds.

In a 2004 study report by the Pratichi Trust, Rana wrote of "some evidence of discrimination based on caste and religion" around the mid-day meal programme in schools. In two of the 15 villages under the study, privileged caste Hindu children refused to eat in school as the cook was a Muslim woman in one and a Dalit in the other.

Despite Bengal's large Dalit population, atrocities against Scheduled Castes remain underreported. Between 2018 and 2022, only 585 cases out of 246,908 complaints were registered in Bengal under the SC/ ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act. The conviction rate has been zero.

The victory in Gidhagram is a milestone, but the larger war against caste discrimination is far from over. For Santana, stepping inside the temple was a moment of triumph. For Bengal, it is a wake-up call. ■

By Rohit Parihar

The desert state of Rajasthan has had a somewhat more placid image compared to its neighbours but that reputation is fast losing its shine. Street violence over perceived slights has often been a bane but what's proving worse is the lack of restraint higher up, with the words and deeds of politicians bordering on the boorish.

This year's Holi brought out some of the symptoms of the rash that has begun to ail the state. It started with the St Angela Sophia School in Jaipur issuing a circular to students to not bring colours to school, possibly because they wanted to avoid any untoward incident of harassment. But it took no time to snowball into a communal controversy, so much so that on March 11, school education minister Madan Dilawar declared that he would write to the Central Board of School Education (CBSE) to take action against the school. The very next day, a tragedy proved that the way some play Holi in the state can be calamitous. Hansraj Meena, 25, who was preparing for an exam at a library in Dausa town near Jaipur, was fatally attacked after he objected to some youths putting colour on him.

After the incident, the police clamped down on Holi hooligans who were harassing people or creating a ruckus. Soon, an overdose of the cure itself became a new headache when devotees were barred from playing Holi at Govind Devji temple complex in Jaipur, ostensibly to prevent a stampede. Many angry devotees chose to respond with a boycott. "This is shocking. The cops

A RASH OF INCIDENTS WITH A COMMUNAL TINGE AROUND HOLI HAS PUT THE BHAJAN LAL GOVT IN A SPOT